

Friday, 10 April 2026

Workshop Plan: Participatory Speculative Design for Feminist Safety Technologies

Overview

Format: One 3-hour workshop per participant group (approximately 60-75 min + 30 min break + 60-75 min). The same workshop is run multiple times with different groups of 2-5 participants across the data collection period.

Location: Lab42, University of Amsterdam

Participants: Female-identifying students in Amsterdam (target 15-20 total across groups)

Facilitator: Kaylee Wu

Pre-Workshop

Participant preparation

- Participants complete the intake questionnaire and consent to the information sheet via Qualtrics before attending.
- Participants also physically sign consent forms on arrival. → also consent for audio recording final presentations.

Room setup

- Tables arranged in a clustered pod, seat participants around 1 not too big table. Avoid classroom rows → the layout should feel collaborative.
- Central "materials station" with collage supplies, paper, markers, sticky notes, stickers, scissors, tape, glue sticks, and other tactile materials.
- Example products on display → safety wearables
- Projector or large screen for schedule/slides.
- Snacks and drinks available throughout, set out before participants arrive and replenished at the break.
- Consent forms and name tags at the entrance.
- Write the rating scale across the top of the whiteboard: *strongly contributes* → *somewhat* → *not really* → *actually makes me feel less safe*.

Equipment and data collection

- Field notebook and pens for note-taking.
- Paper prototyping stencils
- Phone for photographing artefacts and working process.
- Timer → clock or phone.
- Voice recorder for final presentations

Programme (3 hours)

Part 1: Unpacking Safety (65-75 min)

1. Welcome and introductions (15 min)

- Brief overview of the research and what to expect today.
- Housekeeping: recording policy (field notes and artefact photos during the workshop), right to withdraw at any time, break timing.
- Collect signed consent forms from anyone who hasn't returned them yet.
- Icebreaker: Each person shares their name and their favourite place or activity in Amsterdam.

2. Mapping safety landscapes (20 min)

- *Individual activity (8-10 min):*
 - Each participant receives a large sheet of paper and draws or writes a "safety map" of their typical week. Prompt: "Think about the places you move through in a typical week: your route from home to university, your neighbourhood at night, online spaces, social situations. Emphasise moments or places where you feel safe, unsafe, watched, free, constrained. Use drawings, words, symbols, whatever feels right."
- *Group debrief (8-10 min):* Each individual receives a stack of sticky notes and a marker. Find common threads of the most impactful/meaningful themes/factors. Write emerging themes on sticky notes and cluster them on a wall or board. These clusters carry forward into the design activity after the break.

3. Critical framing exercise (30 min)

The theme board from the mapping activity stays at the centre of the room throughout. Groups examine existing safety solutions, rate them collectively, and map their assumptions back onto the theme board.

Setup (3 min) The group receives a set of 5 cards. Each card shows one real existing safety solution or initiative, with a short description and a small image. Facilitator should pick 5 from:

- A walking-home app that tracks your route and alerts contacts (e.g., Life360)
- Smart jewellery with a panic button
- Expanded CCTV in public squares, justified as women's safety
- "Blue light" emergency poles on American campuses
- A self-defence class programme for women
- An AI harassment detection tool on a social platform
- A "safe taxi" service for women (e.g., DivaRide)
- A neighbourhood WhatsApp group for reporting incidents
- Increased street lighting in public spaces

1. Round 1: What does this solution assume safety means? (8 min)

Groups work through their cards together and write out the assumptions on sticky notes: *what does each solution assume safety means?* They should try to write at least one assumption per card within the time, and one sticky note per assumption. Rapid fire style/brain dump. Notes are physically attached to (or placed directly next to) the card they belong to, so each card gradually accumulates a small cluster of assumption notes around it.

2. **Round 2: Does it actually make you feel safer? (10 min)** Now they discuss and rate each solution on a simple scale written out on the white board: *strongly contributes* → *somewhat* → *not really* → *actually makes me feel less safe*.

Prompts:

- Would you actually use this? Why or why not?
- Does it make you feel safer, or just more watched/more responsible/more alert?
- Who does it work for, and who does it fail?

3. **Round 3: Mapping onto lived experience themes (7 min)**

Groups now return to the theme board from the mapping activity (the clusters of sticky notes participants produced when discussing their own safety experiences earlier).

Each sticky note with an assumption of safety should be put on the theme board and place it:

- *Next to a theme* if the kind of safety assumed matches or closely resembles one of the themes participants identified for themselves
- *Under an "Other" section* if it doesn't match any of the themes the group came up with

Brief synthesis (2 min, whole group) Facilitator draws attention to the populated theme board: *"Look at where the stickies landed. Where's the overlap? Where's the gap? What's in the 'Other' pile, and what does that tell us?"*

4. **Bridge to break (2 min)**

- Facilitator previews what comes after the break: Amsterdam set in 2050.
- Briefly introduce the speculative scenario so participants can mull it over during the break.

Break (30 min)

Replenish snacks. Leave the clustered themes and tension board visible so participants can continue talking informally. The facilitator can use this time to jot quick field notes on Part 1 dynamics.

Part 2: Designing Feminist Safety Futures (75 min)

5. **Design brief and making introduction (2 min)**

- Restate the speculative scenario: *"It's Amsterdam, 2050. A new city initiative has given communities full control over how public safety technology is designed and deployed in their neighbourhoods. Your group has been invited to propose a safety technology, but the only rule is that it must centre the needs and knowledge of female identifying students (you guys). What do you create?"*

6. **Crazy 8's (10 min)**

- Each participant takes a sheet of paper and folds it into 8 panels.
- The goal: sketch 8 different ideas for a safety technology in 8 minutes → one per panel. The facilitator calls time halfway.
- Every idea should respond to something on the theme board, but ideas can be playful, impractical, or speculative. Weird is welcome.
- Work individually, no discussion yet.

At the end, each person has 8 rough ideas on a single sheet.

6. Share and select (10 min)

- Each person walks the others shortly through their 8 sketches in ~1-2 minutes. After everyone has shared, the group discusses which ideas resonate most and picks one concept to develop together. This may be a single person's sketch, a combination of two or three, or a new idea that emerges from the discussion.
- The chosen concept doesn't need to be the "best" one but it should be the one the group feels most drawn to explore further. The facilitator circulates to make sure every group lands on something within the time.

7. Speculative design and paper-prototyping (30 min)

- Groups now develop their chosen concept into a tangible paper prototype.
- The goal is to make the idea specific, visible, and discussable → not polished.
- The prototype might include:
 - A sketch or diagram of the technology itself (what it looks like, how it works)
 - A storyboard showing someone using it in a specific moment or scenario
 - Annotations describing the values or principles it embodies
 - Notes on what it deliberately doesn't do, or who it isn't for
 - Any supporting artefacts → a fake interface, a mock advertisement, a user journey, a piece of imagined documentation
- Walk through the available materials → large paper, markers, sticky notes, coloured paper, scissors, tape, magazines for collage.
- While the group works on developing and materialising their concept; the facilitator circulates, asking generative questions:
 - *"Who is this for specifically, can you describe a moment they'd use it?"*
 - *"What happens when someone misuses this?"*
 - *"What would this feel like at 2am on a Tuesday?"*
 - *"Which theme on the board is this responding to? Is there another one it could also speak to?"*
 - *"What did you deliberately leave out, and why?"*
- Brief midway nudge (~15 min in): Facilitator gives a time check and reminds groups to start consolidating their concept into something presentable.

8. Final presentations (10 min)

- Ask for permission again to audio record the presentation.
- The group presents their design concept. They should show their artefact(s) and explain:
 - What is it? What does it do?
 - Which theme(s) from the board does it respond to?
 - What values or principles guide it?
 - What would it feel like to use?

9. Reflective closing (8 min)

- Brief group reflection: *"Looking at everything we've created, what patterns do you notice? What surprised you? What would you want designers to take from this?"*
- Hand out index cards with the prompt *"What does safety on your terms look like?"* Participants write a few sentences (5 min). Collect these as data.

- Carry out post-survey survey
 - Thank participants.
 - Collect and photograph all artefacts before participants leave.
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Post-Workshop

Immediately after each session

- Write up field notes the same day while details are fresh. Include observations about group dynamics, energy shifts, notable exchanges, and anything surprising.
- Photograph all physical artefacts with consistent lighting. Label by group/workshop date.

Across workshop runs

- Keep a running memo of cross-group patterns as you run the same workshop with different groups. Note where groups converge on similar themes or concepts and where they diverge → useful for thematic analysis.
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Materials Checklist

Printed / prepared

- ☐ Consent forms (one per participant)
- ☐ Name tags
- ☐ Cards with pictures+description of existing tools/initiatives
- ☐ Speculative scenario brief → on a slide
- ☐ Reflective closing index cards

Making supplies

- ☐ Large sheets of paper (A3)
- ☐ Markers (different colours)
- ☐ Sticky notes (multiple colours)
- ☐ Magazines for collage (variety of sources)
- ☐ Scissors, glue sticks, tape
- ☐ Coloured paper
- ☐ Pens and pencils
- ☐ Magnets/washi tape

Technology

- ☐ Laptop with the slides
- ☐ Powerpoint with the instructions
- ☐ Projector/screen
- ☐ Phone for artefact photography
- ☐ Voice recorder

Logistics

- [] Snacks and drinks → the sushi + utensils/plates
- [] Spare consent forms
- [] Facilitator field notebook + pens
- [] Clock or timer visible in the room
- [] Wipes for cleaning

Facilitation Notes

Tone: Warm, curious, non-directive.

Power dynamics: Be attentive to who speaks and who doesn't.

Emotional safety: Conversations about safety can surface difficult experiences. Set a norm early on that no one needs to share more than they're comfortable with, and that stepping out for a moment is always fine.

Time management: If an earlier discussion is running long, gently close it rather than cutting into design time. The 30-minute break provides a natural reset if Part 1 goes slightly over.

Consistency across runs: Use the same prompts, provocation cards, and scenario across all workshop groups.

Make pictures during the progress as well, to record the lifecycle of how certain decisions were made/changed.